

FEEDING THE BET

₦186_{BN} SPENT.

ZERO VERIFIED.

An independent M&E review of Nigeria's National Home-Grown School Feeding Programme — Africa's largest school-feeding initiative.

This brief is built on the foundation of **Nigeria's biggest bet on girls' education — the AGILE programme.**

Without reliable school feeding, the gains of AGILE risk being eroded by poor livelihoods. The National Home-Grown School Feeding Programme is the critical bridge that sustains attendance and nutrition — but its effectiveness has never been independently verified. This M&E review examines that missing link.

9,990,862 pupils · 127,000 cooks · 53,000+ schools

All federal claims. None independently verified. No public dashboard. No state-level disclosure since 2020.

TIMELINE

From first launch to a resumption that never came.

Twenty years. Two suspensions. One pattern.

**2005****First launch under Obasanjo administration**

12 pilot states · Partnership for Child Development

**2007****Suspended — poor planning & execution**

Programme dormant for nine years

**2016****Re-launched under NSIO · Buhari administration**

Per-meal rate set at ₦70 · Five-pillar design

**2019****Federal claim: 9.5 million pupils reached**

14 states (2017) → 33+ states by 2022

**2022****Peak claim: 9,990,862 pupils · ₦100 approved but never implemented**

53,000+ schools · 127,000 cooks

**JAN 2024****Tinubu Presidential Panel suspension**

9 million+ pupils & 250,000 jobs stranded

**JAN 2025****Presidential approval to resume**

Programme reinstated in principle

**DEC 2025****₦30 billion+ seized from NSIPA · funds not released to Treasury**

Tribune Online (Akintola, 2025)

SIX NUMBERS

What this programme cost. What it cannot tell us.

Each figure is sourced. None is independently verified by the operator of the programme.

₦186BN

**CLAIMED CUMULATIVE SPEND,
2016–2020**

House Committee on Public Accounts · 66%
cannot be accounted for as direct feeding

9.99M

PEAK PUPILS CLAIMED (2022)

NSIPA federal claim · Zero independent
verification

₦33.8BN

**BUDGET ARITHMETIC GAP, NEVER
RECONCILED**

Component figures sum to ₦219.8BN — stated
total ₦186BN · 6 years without audit

₦30BN+

**NSIPA FUNDS SEIZED · DECEMBER
2025**

Tribune Online · Recovered funds still not
released to Treasury

17 MO.

APPROVAL-TO-RESUMPTION GAP

Jan 2025 presidential approval → mid-2026 ·
Still not running at scale

0

**PUBLIC QUARTERLY REPORTS SINCE
2020**

No dashboard · No state-level data · No
verification framework

FINDING 1

Where did ₦186 billion go?

Budget arithmetic that does not reconcile — 2016 to 2020.



"Outrageous and unacceptable."
— House Committee on Public Accounts, June 2020. Full audit demanded. No public audit report released in six years.

₦33.8 BILLION

UNEXPLAINED GAP · NEVER RECONCILED

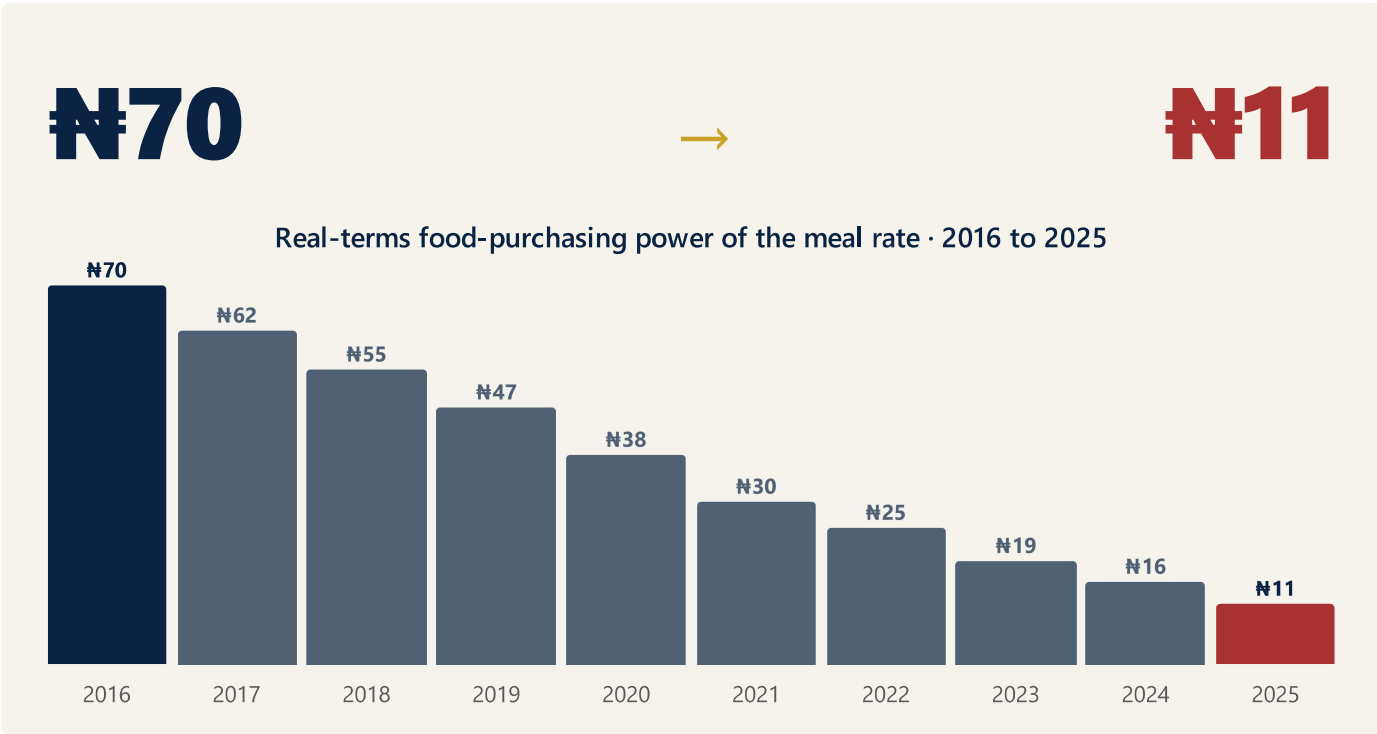
Component years disclosed: ₦63.2BN (2018) + ₦32.2BN (2019) + ₦124.4BN (2020) = ₦219.8BN
Stated cumulative figure: ₦186BN · Difference: ₦33.8BN · No public reconciliation in six years.



FINDING 2

The ₦70 question.

A silent inflation erosion — the programme has been buying less food every year without a budget decision.



NBS Food CPI rose ~150% between 2016 and 2024. The unit cost never changed. ₦70 in 2016 bought one meal; ₦70 in 2025 buys one-sixth of that meal.

WFP regional benchmark: \$0.30–\$0.50/child/day · **Nigeria 2024:** ~\$0.07 · **Nigeria operates at 14–23% of the regional minimum.**

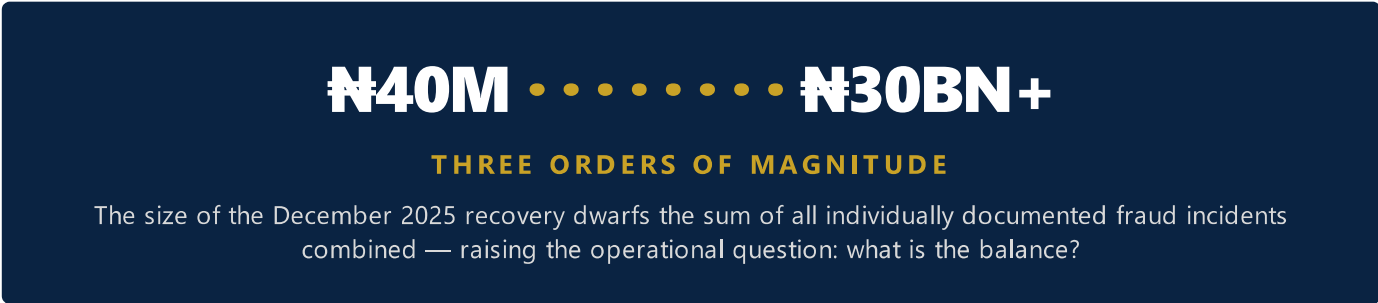
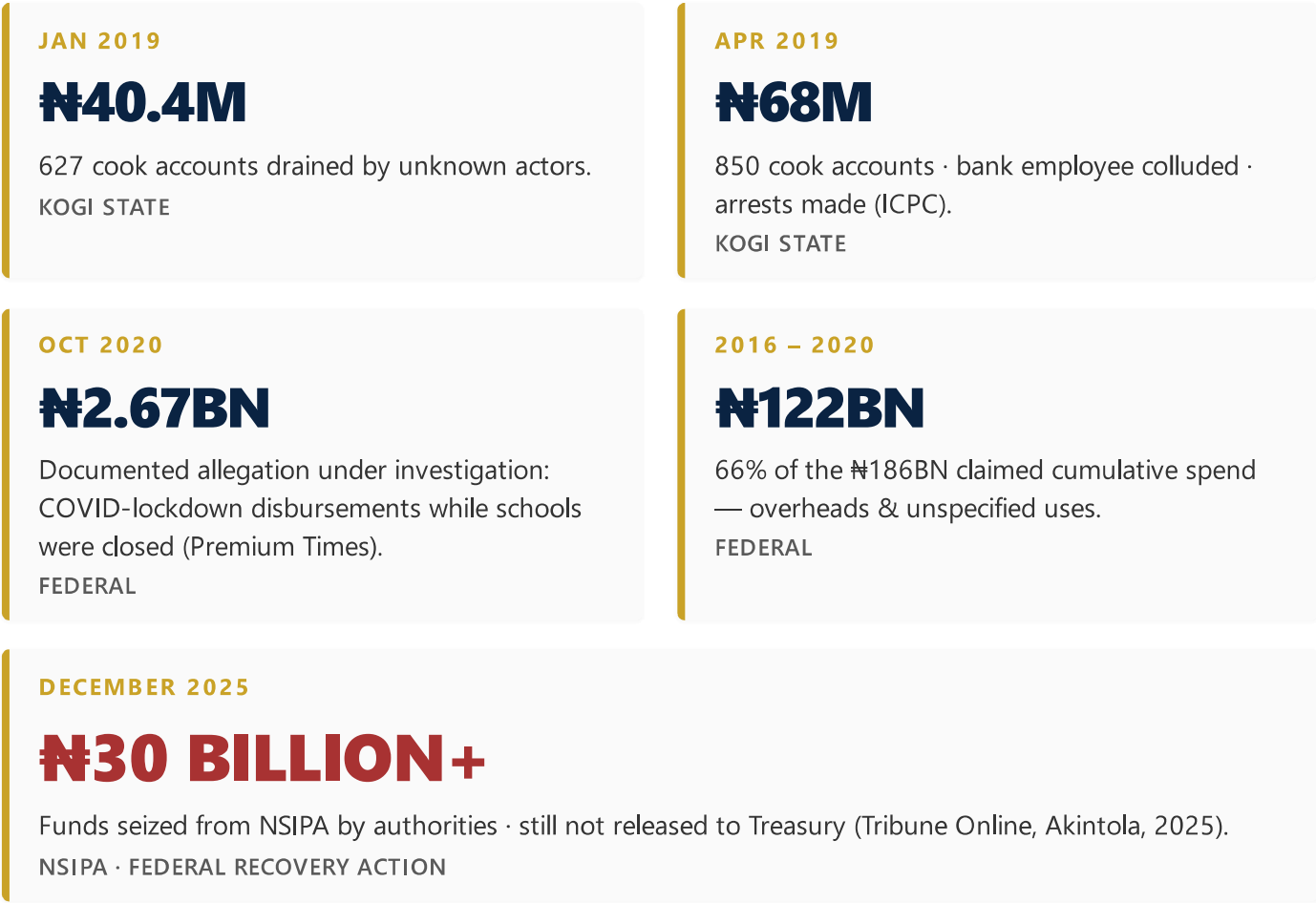
₦100 rate approved by President Buhari in 2022 · **never implemented** before the January 2024 suspension.

NSIPA 2025 target: ₦500–~~₦~~1,000 per child · No gazetted indexation rule · No automatic-review trigger.

FINDING 3

Three orders of magnitude.

From ₦40 million in 2019 to ₦30 billion+ in 2025 — small undetected diversions compound when no verification mechanism exists.



FINDING 4

The programme cannot answer: "How many children received a meal today?"

Measurement coverage of the programme's own theory of change — by causal level.

INPUTS ₦ allocation · Cooks · Food procurement · WASH supplies ⚠ PARTIAL	ACTIVITIES Daily meal preparation & delivery · Deworming · Nutrition education ⚠ PARTIAL	OUTPUTS Meals served · Cooks paid on time · Farmers supplied ✗ NOT VERIFIED	OUTCOMES Enrolment retention · Nutrition · Smallholder income ⚠ PARTIAL · 11–42%	IMPACT Stunting reduction · Learning gains · Rural poverty ✗ NO DATA
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THE M&E PARADOX · SAME PROGRAMME · SAME YEAR · IRRECONCILABLE

WFP SCHOOL MEALS COALITION (2023)

10 million pupils receiving meals

WORLD BANK / NASSCO (2025)

NHGSFP ceased benefits since 2023 — has not resumed

TWO REPUTABLE BODIES · NO PUBLIC DASHBOARD EXISTS TO RESOLVE THE CONTRADICTION

The data infrastructure already exists. NSIPA operates an MIS. NEDI digital platform has onboarded 21 states. A mobile verification application is in use. **What does not exist is the political decision to make the data public.**

WHAT WORKS

Where measurement exists — what the evidence confirms.

Not every finding is critique. These achievements are real. They are also incompletely attributable without verification architecture.

11–42%

RELATIVE ENROLMENT GAINS

8 qualifying studies · 2025 scoping review · Width of range reflects M&E inconsistency, not programme failure

3.8×

GEOGRAPHIC SCALE-UP

From 14 states (2017) to 33+ states by 2022 · A fourfold institutional achievement in five years

127K+

COMMUNITY COOKS AT PEAK

Predominantly women · Documented economic role · Pathway with confirmed positive secondary effects

40% / 20%

FOOD SECURITY: BENEFICIARY VS NON-BENEFICIARY FARMERS

CGIAR/IFPRI 2024 baseline · Two-to-one advantage among smallholders engaged in NHGSFP procurement

\$9 : \$1

RETURN PER DOLLAR (VERIFIED HGSP CONDITIONS)

UN OSAA (Duarte, 2024) macroeconomic ROI for documented programmes

0.4 pp

POVERTY REDUCTION · ALL SIPS COMBINED

World Bank 2025 finding: 'almost no impact' — implementation arithmetic, not concept failure

The argument is not that these achievements are insufficient or unworthy of recognition. The argument is that they **cannot be fully credited or attributed to specific programme mechanisms** without a verification architecture capable of distinguishing genuine programme-induced effects from selection effects, reporting inflation, and input-activity confounds.

INDICATOR	NIGERIA (NHGSFP)	GHANA	RWANDA (WFP/USDA)	INTL BENCHMARK
Scale	9.99M claimed · 2.3M pilot	3.8M (digitised)	140 schools · 7 districts	WFP: \$9 return per \$1
Cost/day	~\$0.05 (₦70)	Not disclosed	\$35 / pupil / year	\$0.30 – \$0.50
M&E	No dashboard · no verification	Digitised · 33% agric uplift	Endline evaluation · targets met	Embedded at design stage

FRAMEWORK

Five minimum conditions.

Under which ₦100BN and a 50-million-pupil target can be verified — and demonstrated.

01 PUBLIC QUARTERLY DASHBOARD

State-level pupil counts and ₦ disbursed within 30 days of quarter-end · By state, LGA, school · BudgIT template already exists · NEDI (21 states) ready.

WHO: NSIPA + FME · **TARGET:** Dashboard live in 90 days · No legislation required.

02 INDEPENDENT VERIFICATION BUDGET LINE

Ring-fence $\geq 1\%$ of annual budget for accredited CSO verification · 1% of ₦100BN = ₦1BN = less than a single documented fraud incident · ANEEJ coalition demonstrated the model in 2019.

WHO: FMF + NSIPA · **TARGET:** 2027 appropriation.

03 BIOMETRIC COOK REGISTRY

Digitise the 107K+ cook registry · Anchor each record to a National Identification Number (NIN) · Link to payment account · N-Power provides the technical precedent · NIMC covers 100M+ Nigerians.

WHO: NSIPA + NIMC · **TARGET:** Pilot 10K cooks across 2 states within 180 days.

04 AUTOMATIC UNIT-COST REVIEW TRIGGER

Legislate: a reviewed rate must be submitted to the National Assembly within 60 days whenever NBS Food CPI exceeds 25% growth from the preceding review baseline · ₦70 → ₦100 took 6 years against 150% inflation.

WHO: FMF + NBS · **TARGET:** Include in the 2026 Finance Act.

05 STATE CO-FINANCING READINESS AUDIT

Publish a readiness score per state across budget commitment, payment infrastructure, school-survey coverage, and MIS integration · Make federal disbursements conditional · Rwanda phased model demonstrates feasibility.

WHO: NSIPA + State MoEs · **TARGET:** Scores for 12 pilot states within 6 months.

THE BET

₦70 per child per day · Africa's largest school feeding programme · 9 million children · One daily meal. The bet was theoretically sound. **The M&E system to verify whether the bet is paying off has yet to be built.**

Full brief · source matrix · all references → github.com/Almuarif17/social-protection-me-nigeria